



Mental Health Consumers who Do Not Attend Community Appointments: Management of (Mental Health) Policy and Procedure

ALERT It is imperative that all consumers who **Do Not Attend** scheduled community mental health appointments are reviewed to determine what follow up is required.

Preamble

Consumer Participation

The Rockingham Peel Group (RKPG) recognises and fully supports the need for the consumer and/or their primary carer to¹:

- Know and exercise their healthcare rights
- Be engaged in their healthcare.
- Have access to information about treatment options.
- Participate in treatment decisions.
- Have access to information about agreed treatment plans.

Scope of Practice

It is the responsibility of each health care provider to ensure all consumer care and therapeutic interventions they provide are within their individual scope of practice. Refer to the [RKPG Policy Writing Guide Summary](#) for further information about Scope of Practice.

Definitions

Risk Assessment	A gathering of information and analysis of the potential outcomes of identified behaviours. Identifying specific risk factors of relevance to an individual, and the context in which they may occur. This process requires linking historical information to current circumstances, to anticipate possible future change.
Clinician	A health professional such as a medical practitioner, nurse, occupational therapist, psychologist or social worker.
Case Manager	A mental health professional employed by a mental health service to help the consumer attain their recovery goals. Case manager undertakes assessment, monitoring, planning, advocacy and linking of the consumers relevant services.
Community Mental Health Service	A service that provides mental health assessment, treatment and care for people in the community.
Consumer	A person who is currently using or has previously used a mental health service.

RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
First Issued	Nov 2021	Revisions	NA	National Standards 1, 5, 6 Mental Health National Standards 1.3, 1.12, 6.7, 6.8, 9.3, 9.4, 10.4.7, 10.6.85
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Multidisciplinary team	A group of health professional who are members of different disciplines (psychiatrist, nurse, social worker etc.) each providing specific services to the consumer.
PSOLIS	Psychiatric Online Service Information System (PSOLIS) is the patient database used by WA public mental health services.

Policy statement

Where a consumer does not attend a scheduled Rockingham Peel community mental health appointment, the community mental health multidisciplinary team must make an informed assessment, which includes consultation with any involved carers/significant others, to identify and take appropriate action.

Procedure

- When a consumer fails to attend a scheduled community mental health appointment the clinician who was expecting to see the consumer is responsible for initiating this procedure.
- Where a Case Manager is involved, they should be informed and be a part of the review. In the absence of a Case Manager the treating team will determine who will respond.
- A risk assessment must be undertaken by the clinician who was expecting to see the client, or the Case Manager as determined by above stated review procedure, at the earliest opportunity.
- Every effort will be made to contact the consumer as soon as possible by:
 - * Contacting the consumer by phone, and other previously agreed methods such as text messaging or leaving a voicemail, to establish why they did not attend and any barriers that may have prevented the consumer attending.
 - * If unable to contact the consumer, subject to consent, contact the family or carer to check the consumer's wellbeing.
 - * Where concerns are raised by family members or others in the community about active community consumers, care will be escalated to the treating team and if out of hours, the Assessment Treatment Team (ATT).
 - * Follow up is based on the consumer's risk assessment and the collateral information received. The treating team/ATT will communicate actions taken to family members/others wherever possible. Next of kin (NOK) or support persons to be notified of outcome where possible.
 - * In the case where there is concern about the patient and the mental health service cannot provide immediate response, notification to WA Police needs to be considered. ([Community Mental Health Status Assessments: Role of Mental Health Clinician Policy](#))
- An action plan, consistent with any risks identified is to be formulated, documented in the consumer's medical record, and implemented. Consideration to using Psychiatric Services Online Information System (PSOLIS) alerts to be taken.
- If no risks are identified, the clinician is to contact the consumer to re-organise the appointment.

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- * The clinician is also to determine if there are any difficulties the consumer may have regarding the appointment e.g. need for transport. Written confirmation of the new appointment date and time is to be provided to the consumer.

Risk assessment

- The clinician/Case Manager will also consider the consumer's individual circumstances when assessing risk including:
 - * Level of urgency of original appointment.
 - * Co-morbidities or physical health.
 - * Previous history of non-attendance.
 - * Consumer access to a phone.
 - * Patient with no fixed address.
 - * Consumer other commitments e.g. work, study.
 - * Consumers previous understanding of attendance at appointments/groups.
- If unable to contact the consumer/carer the clinician/Case Manager will assess the consumer risk by:
 - * Checking PSOLIS to identify whether the patient has had contact with another mental health service.
 - * Reviewing the consumer's history and recent contacts with RKPG mental health documented in the medical record; for some consumers disorganisation can be a significant symptom of relapse.
 - * Reviewing the consumer's most recent Risk Assessment for risk of physical harm to self/others or from others.
 - * Reviewing potential risk to the consumer reputation or financial situation.
 - * Consideration should be given to contacting the consumer GP.
- The multidisciplinary team is to review the management of such consumers as soon as is practical.
- Where a person 'Does Not Attend' (DNA) for multiple scheduled appointments the multidisciplinary team is to review the case and take appropriate action. This may include actions included above. It may also include no further action and/or closure of the referral/case. All actions are to be documented in PSOLIS and the person's medical record.

Roles and responsibilities

- The **clinician** who conducts the follow up contact is to review the relevant records and identify any risks and record action taken in the integrated progress notes in the medical record. The Case Manager, if not the follow up clinician, must review the integrated progress notes and update the Risk Assessment Management Plan.
- The **multidisciplinary team** is to review the consumer's management as per the risk identified in the risk assessment and direct an appropriate course of action.

Record keeping

Clinicians who take actions to locate, assess and/or treat a consumer who has declined assessment or follow-up must document those actions, as well as their assessment of the consumer, in the consumer's medical record.

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Compliance monitoring

An annual audit of patients' health records is to be conducted to ascertain compliance with this policy.

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References

1. Australian Commission on Safety and Quality in Health Care (ACSQH). The National Safety and Quality Health Service Standards Safety and Quality Improvement Guide: Standard 1 Governance for Safety and Quality in Health Service Organisations. 2nd ed. (Version 2) 2021. Available from <https://www.safetyandquality.gov.au/our-work/assessment-to-the-nsqhs-standards/>

Links

[Department of Health \(DoH\) Clinical Care of People With Mental Health Problems Who May Be At Risk Of Becoming Violent Or Aggressive Policy](#)

[DoH Clinical care of people who may be suicidal](#)

[DoH Community Mental Health Status Assessments: Role of Mental Health Clinicians Policy](#)

[DoH Missing Person Policy](#)

[Fiona Stanley Fremantle Hospital Group Did not attend: Mental Health outpatient appointments policy](#)

[National Safety and Quality in Health Care Standards](#)

[National Standards for Mental Health Services](#)

[RKPG Missing or Suspected Missing Patients \(Acute\) Policy and Procedure](#)

[SMHS Missing or suspected missing mental health patients](#)

[WA Country Health Service \(WACHS\) Management of Consumers Who Do Not Attend Community Mental Health Appointment Policy](#)

[WA Mental Health Act 2014](#)

National Standards



National Standards for Mental Health Services

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